



Academic integrity in theses

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Plagiarism

- Let's start by reading RTU guidelines "*Breach of Academic Integrity and Breach Consideration Procedures*":

Plagiarism is "the use of published or unpublished works (including extracts, statements, etc.) of another author without making an explicit reference to the author and/or the work, and the use of content generated by an artificial intelligence tool without making an explicit reference to the use of the artificial intelligence tool."

Plagiarism

- Incorrect usage of another person's work can be manifested both as a violation of copyright and **deception of the reader**
 - Reader must be able to **distinguish between** the contribution of the **author of the work** and the contribution of the **author of the source**
- The person committing plagiarism **appropriates the status of the creator** of a work by another author
 - **The plagiarizer claims the same status as the original author**

Plagiarism forms

Plagiarism generally has **two forms**:

- **Linguistic expression** (appropriating **expression**)
 - Includes: text, tables, figures, diagrams, source code, data etc.
 - And no references given (or copying is done in too large amounts)
- **Information** (appropriating **ideas**)
 - Includes: ideas, concepts, algorithms, techniques, methods, methodologies etc.
 - And no references given (or copying is done in too large amounts)
- *Both forms are considered severe violation*

References

You should **give references** for everything of **both forms** (expressions and ideas) that is not your own work

- **Give references in your thesis text as well as list the references at the end of the thesis**
 - Note that the reference should be given in the text location where your text contains something from the source. Not just at the beginning or at the end of a paragraph.
- **Give references to primary sources + any secondary sources that you used**
 - Encyclopedias (including Wikipedia), textbooks, lecture slides, review-type articles etc. are not considered primary sources. Reference them, but seek primary sources as well
- It's irrelevant whether you paraphrased or translated the text – references are required in any case

Plagiarism types (1, 2)

- **Not acknowledging the sources used**
 - Not giving all references in all needed places
 - Pretending to be the author of someone else's idea/work
- **Not using quotation marks when using direct copy** of some source's text
 - Direct translation is considered equivalent to direct copying
 - You need to use quotation marks in both cases
 - Exception – copying mathematics does not require quotation marks
 - By the way, in our field, direct copying of text is actually rarely needed

Plagiarism types (3, 4)

- **Imitating re-expression when taking a direct copy**
 - Paraphrasing or translating text sentence-by-sentence to simulate originality of your text and to hide plagiarism
 - You should understand that copying and then paraphrasing or translating is not the same as doing literature analysis and summarization or writing comparative analysis etc.
- **Self-plagiarism**
 - Not referencing your own previous work
 - Trying to benefit the second time for the same work
 - If you reuse something from your own previous work (e.g., bachelor thesis), it should be referenced too

Plagiarism types (5, 6)

- **Inappropriately using text generation or using it without a reference**
 - Without acknowledging the fact that the text was generated
 - Generating in large amounts
 - Generating things that should have been done by yourself
- **Letting somebody else write your work**
 - With or without paying for it

Dimensions of plagiarism

- As you saw there are several types (dimensions) how we can look at (and measure) plagiarism
 - **We are not looking at just some text matching percentage**
- This means that, for example,
 - If you extensively reuse someone else's work, it is plagiarism even if you use quotation marks, proper references, and paraphrased the text
 - If you are not referencing other people's work, it is plagiarism even if you did not copy any text
 - If you generated your text in large amounts, it is plagiarism even if otherwise you did nothing wrong
 - Etc.

Additional notes

- If you have a situation where you are not sure whether you should give a reference or not, its better to give reference
- “I forgot” is not an argument for not quoting or not referencing sources

Sanctions

- Severity of sanctions depend on severity of violation:
 - Lowering grade, issuing a warning
 - Writing new thesis on new topic
 - Exmatriculation
- We have precedents in all levels of severity
- People involved in deciding on sanctions are:
 - Special academic integrity committee
 - Includes study program's director, vice dean, plagiarism specialist, student's supervisor
 - Others
 - Thesis reviewer, thesis defense committee, faculty dean, university rector
 - Humans are making all decisions
 - So called "plagiarism detection systems" are just helping by providing information

Text generation

Innapropriate use of AI text generation

- It becomes a serious problem if:
 - You use AI where you absolutely **should have been using your own abilities**
 - You use AI in **large amounts**
 - You use AI **without proper citation**
- *“Where you should not have used AI?” “What amount is too large?”* – these questions are **decided by the according committees**
- Similarly to text-copying plagiarism, **no concrete threshold** for allowable amount is defined
 - This is a **complex question** where we take into account **several factors**:
 - Generated/copied text amount, existence of proper references, location in the work, previous offenses, ...

Reference to the generation tool

- If content has been generated, this fact must be acknowledged with a reference
- **Reference syntax:**
Tool developer. Tool name and version (if known). Prompt: *The used prompt*. Web address. [accessed date].
Example:
OpenAI. ChatGPT 5. Prompt: *What is artificial intelligence?*. <https://chatgpt.com/share/123>. [accessed 30.11.2024.].
 Link to chat
- And in text accordingly: Artificial intelligence is xxx xxx xxx (OpenAI, 2025).
- Of course, it is not just about *ChatGPT* but about any tools that generate something

When content generation is allowed?

- **Allowed:**

- If not related to the skills and knowledge the student is expected to demonstrate
- If not related to the original contribution expected of the student
- If the generation is authorized or supported by the course professor
- If the generation is required by the assignment

- **Not allowed:**

- If no reference to the tool used is added
- If the content is generated in large volumes
- If the content is generated where the learner needs to demonstrate their contribution, knowledge and skills

Notes so there are no misunderstandings

- **Spelling and grammar** correction tools are not regarded as text generation tools
 - For example, suggestions from *Grammarly*
- Using **translation tools** are not regarded as text generation tools
 - *Google Translate*, *DeepL*, as well as translation using large language models
- If text generation is allowed for any purpose, it must be understood that the student is in any case **fully responsible** for the text generated
 - Factual accuracy, critical thinking, correct logic, correct references, etc.
 - It is not the responsibility of the supervisor to look after any of those things

Thank you for your attention!